Family Camping Checklist

Foothills Kids Outdoors · Print it, pack it, tick it off together

Before you go

- [ ] Book your site, or check whether your campground takes bookings or is first-come (shop.albertaparks.ca for provincial parks), and plan a backup
- [ ] Random camping on public land in the Eastern Slopes? Each adult (18+) needs a Public Lands Camping Pass ($20 for 3 days or $30 a year, kids free, 14 days max per spot). Not needed in paid campgrounds or Kananaskis.
- [ ] Camping or stopping in Kananaskis or the Bow Valley? Your vehicle needs a Kananaskis Conservation Pass ($15 a day or $90 a year). Camping fees still apply.
- [ ] Check fire bans at albertafirebans.ca, and again on the day you leave (they can change daily)
- [ ] Check the weather and road conditions
- [ ] Tell someone where you're going and when you'll be back
- [ ] Note where cell coverage ends

Shelter and sleep

- [ ] Tent, poles, pegs, mallet, tarp
- [ ] Sleeping bags rated for cold nights, pads, pillows
- [ ] Kids' comfort item for bedtime

Kitchen

- [ ] Stove, fuel, lighter or matches
- [ ] Pots, plates, cups, utensils, can opener
- [ ] Cooler and ice, plenty of water
- [ ] Store food, garbage, coolers and anything with a smell in a hard-sided vehicle or bear-proof locker, never in your tent (alberta.ca/bears-and-outdoor-recreation). Garbage bags
- [ ] Dish soap, sponge, wash basin

Clothes (layers, even in summer)

- [ ] Warm jacket, toque, rain jacket
- [ ] Extra socks, sturdy shoes, sandals for camp
- [ ] Spare outfit for each kid (they will get wet)

Safety

- [ ] First aid kit, kids' medicine, allergy meds
- [ ] Bear spray on your hip, not in the pack, and know how to use it
- [ ] Headlamp or flashlight for each person, extra batteries
- [ ] Sunscreen, bug spray, hats
- [ ] Whistle for each kid, and teach "hug a tree" if lost
- [ ] Life jackets near water, and close watching by cold rivers
- [ ] Stay off ice
- [ ] Kid-free zone around the fire and stove
- [ ] Treat creek water before drinking
- [ ] Change kids out of wet clothes right away

Kid fun

- [ ] Scavenger hunt printout (trail-quest.github.io/Foothills-kids-outdoors/scavenger-hunt.html)
- [ ] Magnifying glass, bug jar, field guide
- [ ] Cards or a small game for rainy hours
- [ ] Marshmallows and roasting sticks, if fires are allowed

Leave no trace

- [ ] Pack out all garbage
- [ ] Leave gates as you found them
- [ ] Put the fire out: soak it, stir it, soak it again, until it's cool to the touch (alberta.ca/campfire-safety)
- [ ] Leave what you find (Leave No Trace Canada)
- [ ] Respect wildlife: watch from a distance, never feed

Rules and fees change; check official sources before you go. Last checked Oct 14, 2026. More family camping ideas: trail-quest.github.io/Foothills-kids-outdoors/camping-foothills.html